



Tianjin Binhai Library

A spectacular, futuristic modern space that has become a Chinese architectural icon

The Binhai Library, in Tianjin, near Beijing, is a tribute to Modernism. The unorthodox space was designed by the Dutch architecture firm MVRDV and the Tianjin Urban Planning and Design Institute. Constructed in just 3 years, its doors opened to the public in 2017.

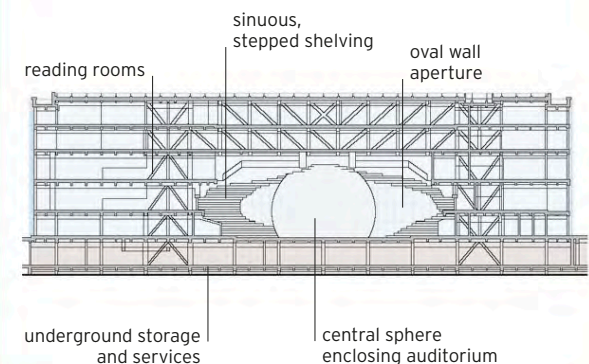
The sleek, five-story library covers 362,750 square ft (33,700 square m). It forms part of a cluster of cultural and educational buildings that were created at around the same time. The main entrance leads into a magnificent central atrium, which is for circulating, sitting, and reading. The first and second floors include reading rooms, book stacks, and relaxation areas; the upper floors contain meeting rooms, offices, computer and audio rooms, and two rooftop patios.

Spherical core

At the center of the space-age atrium is a gigantic sphere, or orb. Inside the orb is an auditorium, with seating for 100 people; above the orb, circular roof lighting helps to maximize illumination. Around the atrium are breathtaking, floor-to-ceiling shelves of books. However, some of the terraced shelves double as seats and stairs, and many of the “books” on the shelves are in fact imitations, created from embossed aluminum plates to resemble the real thing.

THE EYE OF BINHAI

The architectural highlight of the library is the spherical atrium, which comprises a large open space with a luminous orb at its center that is surrounded by shelves. A circular skylight above the orb, combined with louvres and glass windows at ground level, allows natural light to penetrate the interior. The orb is referred to as the Eye. To add to the effect, the shelving curves around the orb, its contours mimicking the outline of an eye. An oval shape punched through the exterior walls also creates a resemblance to an iris when the building is viewed from outside.



The library has the **capacity to hold** more than **1 million books** in its collection

◁ UNDULATING SHELVES

Floor-to-ceiling shelving in the main atrium flows around the central sphere, creating a spectacular sculptural effect and dissolving any clear distinctions between walls, floor, and ceiling.

▷ LOOKING IN

The interior and exterior of the library were ingeniously designed to represent a giant eye, with a glowing white iris at its center.

